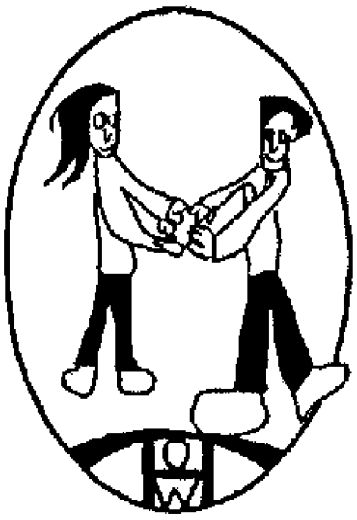
Howbridge Infant School



English Policy

With additional **Reading/Phonics Policy** attached

February 2026

POLICY NAME: English **DATE OF REVIEW: February 2026**

Aims and priorities for subject teaching and learning

The overarching aim for English in the national curriculum is to promote high standards of language and literacy by equipping pupils with a strong command of the spoken and written words, and to develop their love of literature through widespread reading for enjoyment. The national curriculum for English aims to ensure that all pupils:

- read easily, fluently and with good understanding
- develop the habit of reading widely and often, for both pleasure and information
- acquire a wide vocabulary, an understanding of grammar and knowledge of linguistic conventions for reading, writing and spoken language
- appreciate our rich and varied literary heritage
- write clearly, accurately and coherently, adapting their language and style in and for a range of contexts, purposes and audiences
- use discussion in order to learn; they should be able to elaborate and explain clearly their understanding and ideas
- are competent in the arts of speaking and listening, making formal presentations, demonstrating to others and participating in debate

Spoken language

Spoken language is an important aspect of the whole curriculum - cognitively, socially and linguistically. Spoken language underpins the development of reading and writing so teachers should ensure the continual development of pupil's confidence and competence in spoken language and listening skills. In addition, all pupils should be enabled to participate in and gain knowledge, skills and understanding associated with the artistic practice of drama.

Reading

The programmes of study for reading consists of two dimensions

- word reading
- comprehension (both listening and reading)

Skilled word reading involves both the speedy working out of the pronunciation of unfamiliar printed words (decoding) and the speedy recognition of familiar printed words. Underpinning both is the understanding that the letters on the page represent the sounds in spoken words. Phoneme awareness is important as a method to decode and recognise new written phonemes in words by sounding them out. The main goal is to ensure children can read all taught sounds.

Good comprehension skills are developed through pupils' experience of high quality discussion with the teacher, as well as from reading and discussing a range of stories, poems and non-fiction texts.

Writing

The programmes of study for writing consists of

- transcription (spelling and handwriting)
- composition (articulating ideas and structuring them in speech and writing)

In addition, pupils are taught how to plan, revise, edit and evaluate their writing.

Spelling, vocabulary, grammar and punctuation

Pupils need to be taught how to understand the relationships between words, how to understand the nuances in meaning, and how to develop their understanding of, and the ability to use, figurative language. Pupils need to learn how to work out and clarify the meanings of unknown words and words with more than one meaning. Pupils are taught to use the elements of spelling, grammar and punctuation.

Sources

The National Curriculum 2014
Non Statutory teacher assessment framework KS1 April 2024
Early years foundation stage Statutory Framework November 2024
Development Matters September 2023
Little Wandle Letters and Sounds Revised
Penpals – Handwriting scheme
Jonathan Bond The English Unit Toolkit

Strategies for teaching

Speaking and Listening

Speaking and Listening skills are taught, modelled and reinforced in all curriculum areas. Opportunities are made for all children to speak clearly, both formally and informally in a range of contexts.
Children are encouraged to use speaking and listening skills for drama and imaginative play.

Writing including grammar, punctuation and spelling

Writing skills are taught creatively across all areas of the curriculum. All classrooms have a phonics display that all children can access for independent writing using a range of resources.
English lessons are taught daily in EYFS, Years 1 and 2; these lessons may include reading, speaking and listening or writing. Writing skills are modelled by the teacher using shared and guided writing. Children explore writing in a range of genres including non-fiction, poetry and fiction.
English planning in KS1 has a clear structure including the audience, text type, the purpose, the form and the tools the children will need to use. These are displayed on the class working walls.
Writing and spelling skills are also taught every day during a phonics lesson.
Grammar, punctuation and spelling (GPS) lessons are planned for daily in Year 2 for children who are accessing phase 6 phonics.
Handwriting is taught x3 times a week following the whole school handwriting scheme.
In Year 1 and EYFS fine motor skills and letter formation is also developed through malleable play (such as dough disco, funky fingers station and the writing area). Magic wands are used in Early Years as part of our 'nip, flip and grip' approach, children are clearly modelled the correct letter formation using rhymes for each letter.

Independent writing sessions take place regularly to give the children the opportunity to express their knowledge and skills they have developed with unaided writing tasks.

Reading and phonics

Please see the attached separate reading and phonics policy for a detailed explanation.

Makaton

The children are introduced to the 'Sign of the Week' to support Early Language Development

Planning, marking and feedback

Long, medium, and short-term plans are based on the objectives from the appropriate curriculums, for continuity in learning, year teams plan together with daily plans adapted for the needs of each group.
Speaking and Listening activities are planned into all areas of the curriculum. It is identified on each year group's planning and the whole school curriculum map.

Assessments are regularly updated and tracked on Sonar (online tracking system). Children who require extra support are quickly identified and an intervention is put in place for them.
Each child has an individual reading diary which moves between school and home. This creates an ongoing log of the child's reading throughout the year.
Marking is formative, summative and interactive. Regular feedback is given in terms of learning objectives achieved, future targets and challenges set during the lesson.

Children are aware of the expected outcomes of their writing through our English working walls which display learning intentions and success criteria.
Teachers plan activities that allow for 'mastery' within the subject. All children have the opportunity to 'master' areas within the subject at their own level. Teachers acknowledge areas within writing children have mastered by annotating work with reasons.

Assessment, recording and reporting

Assessments are made regularly, recorded and reported to parents following school and National guidelines.
English has an assessment focus relating to ability, which informs planning and feedback about progress.
Targets are set and monitored regularly, these are communicated to parents at parent consultation evenings.
Children's reading and writing assessments are recorded daily on Sonar and in books, but formally half termly assessments take place for the writing progress wall.
Teacher assessments are made alongside children's work, to parents in pupils' annual reports and twice during the year at parents evening where parents receive a progress update. Continual assessments can be seen by parents at informal celebration assemblies and 'open door' mornings/afternoons.
All children are formally assessed on entry using the statutory Reception Baseline Assessment in EYFS . In Year 1 all children are assessed against the National Phonics Screening Check and at the end of Key Stage 1 against the Year 2 national standards.

Inclusion - equal opportunities, racial awareness, gender, SEN

We aim to set suitable learning targets, respond to pupils' diverse needs and overcome potential barriers to learning and assessment for groups and individuals.
More able pupils are taught in their own class and challenged through differentiated questioning, group work and extra tasks. The work set for them may encourage them to work at greater depth and involve different objectives.
Teachers include all pupils in the English lesson with differentiated activities that are adapted to pupils' special needs according to their provision maps/One Page Profiles. These pupils also receive individual/small group support and practice with carefully planned activities to meet their needs. Care plans and advice from other professionals, e.g. speech and language therapists, are also followed.

Resource use, monitoring and acquisition

Resources are held in classrooms. There is a central resource that includes big books, phonic activities, creative writing pots and library stock.
Each class in the year group has the same resources where possible so that all children have equal access and opportunity.
Use of resources are monitored through planning, subject reviews and peer lesson observations to ensure that curriculum needs are met. Resources are updated in consultation with the staff on a needs basis.
An action plan is written and reviewed annually in line with the School Improvement Plan.
Staff ensure that when purchasing resources that this is in line with our Climate Action plan with sustainability in mind. For example, not over ordering books and/or ordering sustainable products.

Links with other subjects including SMSC

Speaking and listening, reading and writing are an integral part of almost all curriculum areas as a form of reading and recording experience and information. Children are provided with opportunities to practise and apply their skills and knowledge to real life situations. Writing skills are reinforced during the teaching of other curriculum subjects.
Technology is used within English when it is the most efficient and effective way of meeting the lesson objectives.
Children learn to respond appropriately to texts from other cultures and to those written by their peers.
Children also apply their English skills such as writing and speaking and listening through clubs such as Planet Protectors and Eco Council which focus on the importance of climate changes and sustainability.

Monitoring and evaluation of teaching and learning

Monitoring takes place through scrutiny of planning, lesson observations and work sampling by the senior management team, during staff meetings and during moderations with other local schools.
Progress is monitored by the headteacher and senior leaders through scrutiny of data, moderation and independent writing samples/assessments.

Each year group moderate their children's work together and analyse their data as a team every half term. Each class teacher has termly pupil progress meeting to discuss progress and potential barriers to learning or the need for further challenge.

Staff and school development

Staff and school development needs are identified through School Evaluation and Development Planning and Performance Management procedures.

Howbridge Infant School is a member of the English Hub at Myland Primary School. This is a designated centre of excellence as defined by the DfE. This offers regular training and CPD across all areas of the English curriculum which many staff members attend and then share in our staff meetings.

Regular training and updates has been delivered for all teaching and support staff from the Little Wandle Letters and Sounds revised systematic, synthetic phonics programme (SSP).

Relevant initiatives and reports from DFE/OFSTED may necessitate staff and school development.

Review

This policy will be reviewed annually as part of the subject development programme. It will be re-drafted periodically as necessary taking account of the school's development plan and new local and national curriculum requirements.

Howbridge Infant School

Reading and Phonics Policy

February 2025

Howbridge Infant School

POLICY NAME: Reading **DATE OF REVIEW: February 2026**

Vision

Intent

Phonics (reading and spelling)

At Howbridge Infant School, we believe that all our children can become fluent readers and writers. This is why we teach reading through *Little Wandle Letters and Sounds Revised,* which is a systematic and synthetic phonics programme. We start teaching phonics in Reception and follow the *Little Wandle Letters and Sounds Revised* progression, which ensures children build on their growing knowledge of the alphabetic code, mastering phonics to read and spell as they move through school.

As a result, all our children are able to tackle any unfamiliar words as they read. At Howbridge Infant School, we also model the application of the alphabetic code through phonics in shared reading and writing, both inside and outside of the phonics lesson and across the curriculum. We have a strong focus on language development for our children because we know that speaking and listening are crucial skills for reading and writing in all subjects.

Comprehension

At Howbridge Infant School, we value reading as a crucial life skill. By the time children leave us, they read confidently for meaning and regularly enjoy reading for pleasure. Our readers are equipped with the tools to tackle unfamiliar vocabulary. We encourage our children to see themselves as readers for both pleasure and purpose.

Because we believe teaching every child to read is so important, we have a phonics lead who drives the early reading programme in our school. Teachers are highly skilled at teaching phonics and reading, so everyone teaches with fidelity to the *Little Wandle Letters and Sounds Revised* programme.

Aims

For all pupils to

- Read fluently and confidently at and beyond age-appropriate expectations
- Enjoy reading and develop a love of books
- Acquire a wide vocabulary and develop an interest and love of words
- Understand fully what they read
- Be able to use reading independently across the curriculum
- Appreciate our rich and varied literary heritage
- Monitor and self-correct their own reading
- Understand how authors craft their writing
- Know and understand a range of genres

Reading Curriculum

Reading is multi-faceted and so this section is organised under the following headings

- General information
- Word reading
- Fluency
- Comprehension
- Vocabulary

- Becoming a researcher
- Becoming a reader at school
- Becoming a reader at home
- Enjoying reading

General Information

- In EYFS 'Development Matters' and the EYFS Framework (Updated 2024) are followed
- In years 1 – 2, our reading curriculum follows the National Curriculum. This sets out the objectives that each year group teaches and shows the progression within and across year groups.
- The school takes a mastery approach to learning objectives and levels of text. Unless a child has a special need related to reading, they will work on the objectives and age-appropriate texts for their year group. Age-appropriate texts for each year group have been identified.
- We use the Little Wandle Letters and Sounds Revised as our systematic synthetic phonics programme.

Word Reading

Implementation

Daily phonics lessons in Reception and Year 1

We teach phonics for 30 minutes a day. In Reception, we build from 10-minute lessons, with additional daily oral blending games, to the full-length lesson as quickly as possible. Each Friday, we review the week's teaching to help children become fluent readers.

Children make a strong start in Reception: teaching begins as soon as we are able to on completion of the Reception Baseline tests in Autumn 1.

We follow the *Little Wandle Letters and Sounds Revised* expectations of progress:

- Children in Reception are taught to read and spell words using Phase 2 and 3 Grapheme-phoneme Correspondence (GPCs), and words with adjacent consonants (Phase 4) with fluency and accuracy.
- Children in Year 1 review Phases 3 and 4 and are taught to read and spell words using Phase 5 GPCs with fluency and accuracy.

Please see the *Reception and Year 1 progression document for more information.*

Keep-up lessons ensure every child learns to read

Any child who needs additional practice has daily Keep-up support, taught by a fully trained adult. Keep-up lessons match the structure of class teaching, and use the same procedures, resources and mantras, but in smaller steps with more repetition, so that every child secures their learning.

We timetable daily phonics lessons for any child in Year 2 who is not fully fluent at reading or has not passed the Phonics Screening Check. These children urgently need to catch up, so the gap between themselves and their peers does not widen.

Teaching reading: Reading practice sessions twice a week in reception and year 1

We teach children to read through reading practice sessions twice a week. These:

- are taught by a fully trained adult to small groups of approximately six children
- use books matched to the children's secure phonic knowledge using the *Little Wandle Letters and Sounds Revised* assessments.
- are monitored by the class teacher, who rotates and works with each group on a regular basis.

Each reading practice session has a clear focus, so that the demands of the session do not overload the children's working memory. The reading practice sessions have been designed to focus on three key reading skills:

- decoding
- prosody: teaching children to read with understanding and expression and comprehension: teaching children to understand the text.

In Reception these sessions start at Week 4 of Little Wandle. Children who are not yet decoding have additional blending practice in small groups, so that they quickly learn to blend and can begin to read books.

In Year 2, children read at least once a week to an adult.

Fluency

Fluency is a focus throughout the school particularly as texts get harder. Here teachers use a combination of modelling, echo reading, choral reading, readers' theatre, use of actions and paired reading to teach fluency. Children will receive a regular fluency session and take home to practise if appropriate.

Comprehension

The set of reading comprehension skills taught in our school are as follows:

- Core skills
  - Clarifying (retrieval, vocabulary)
  - Inferring
- Auxiliary skills
  - Imagining
  - Linking
  - Predicting
  - Summarising
- Evaluation skills
  - Understanding purpose and viewpoint
  - Understanding text organisation
  - Understanding writers' use of language

- Comprehension is first introduced in Reception by asking children questions about the books they are listening to, reading or sharing
- Teachers may also use active reading strategies either within these sessions, other reading lessons or across the curriculum. These include drama, visualisation, diagrammatic representation, text restructuring, writing from reading, cloze, labelling, circling/ highlighting/underlining (text marking) and sequencing.

Vocabulary

- Vocabulary is taught directly and indirectly
- Indirect teaching includes:
    - Engaging in oral language with adults
    - Listening to adults read
    - Regular reading themselves
- Direct teaching includes:
    - Teaching children specific words, e.g. through games and activities
    - Teaching a set of words
    - Repeated exposure to vocabulary across the curriculum
    - Morphemic analysis, e.g. word meanings are determined from their parts- suffixes, prefixes

Becoming a Researcher

- A distinct strand of the curriculum is dedicated to this important life-skill
- It is taught mainly through other subjects. It enables our children to research independently by the time they leave our school, thereby being prepared for the KS2 curriculum.

Becoming a Reader at School

- Every child has a reading record
- Reading books are matched accurately to each child's phonic development
- In all year groups the children are heard to read individually during two group sessions and a class practise session. Children in the lowest 20% of readers are heard additionally to this as well.
- All books in the Little Wandle scheme are phonetically regular reading books, decodable books
- In EYFS and KS1, children read personally selected books in class at least once a week. We call this ERIC time (Everyone Read In Class).
- Across the school, 'storytime' occurs regularly
- Every class has an attractive reading area and a reading chart that records home reading (our 'Bookworms').
- Teachers plan opportunities for reading across the curriculum. These enable pupils to routinely apply the skills they are learning in English.
- The school library is accessed regularly.The library is used before and after school by Bridge the Gap (extended schools club).
- Library staff are welcomed into school and our pupils are encouraged to take part in the annual 'Summer and Winter Reading Challenge'.

Becoming a Reader at Home

- Parents/carers are offered a range of workshops each year to update their knowledge and the school expectations of how to support their children, e.g. Little Wandle phonics and a workshop linked to reading expectations.
- Children are expected to read to an adult or be read to at home as often as is possible. Incentives are offered for this reading at home.
- The decodable reading practice book is taken home to ensure success is shared with the family.
- Reading for pleasure books also go home for parents to share and read to children.
- We offer Little Wandle workshops for parents and carers using the *Little Wandle Letters and Sounds Revised* parents' resources to support them with the programme.

Enjoying Reading

We believe our way of teaching, as detailed above, will create children who enjoy reading. Children are further encouraged through the following strategies:

- Adults using the language of reading for 'fun', 'enjoyment' and 'pleasure'

- Staff enthusing about reading (to both parents and children)
- The use of adults as role models
- The use of reading buddies
- Book swaps
- Displaying books neatly and attractively across the school and creating displays that encourage reading
- The use of high quality texts with depth and interest in story, character, illustration, vocabulary, structure and subject matter in reading lessons
- Class 'Celebration' assemblies.
- Reading breakfasts

February 2026
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